

# Golfo Dulce Poison Dart Frog Care Guide

*Phyllobates vittatus*

Red Rocks Exotic Reptiles · Reviewed October 2026 · Version 2.0

Provide a humid leaf-litter floor with excellent drainage, tiny cultured prey and a coherent amphibian supplementation program. Excess heat is a greater routine danger than lack of a basking lamp.

## Species Profile

**Common name:** Golfo Dulce Poison Dart Frog

**Scientific name:** *Phyllobates vittatus*

**Adult size:** About 1-1.4 in (2.5-3.5 cm) snout-to-vent length

**Captive lifespan:** About 10-15 years is a captive planning range. Typical captive lifespan is a planning estimate, not a measured statistical average.

**Native range:** Golfo Dulce region, southwestern Costa Rica

**Habitat and activity:** Diurnal; humid lowland forest floor, leaf litter and stream-edge cover

**Diet:** Cultured flightless fruit flies and other tiny invertebrates

**Care difficulty:** Intermediate

## Shopping List

- Secure enclosure at least 24 × 18 × 18 in (61 × 46 × 46 cm; L × W × H) for one adult; see Housing for exceptions and group arrangements.
- Digital thermometers for different zones; a suitable hygrometer; timer for a consistent day/night cycle.
- Species-appropriate substrate and multiple stable hides or covered retreats.
- Reliable supply of the staple foods described below, clean feeding tools and a transport container.
- Appropriate overhead heat source if required, controlled by a compatible thermostat; infrared thermometer for surfaces.
- Appropriate visible lighting and, where recommended below, a linear UVB fixture with measured shade and exposure zones.
- Amphibian-safe conditioner that treats both chlorine and chloramine, powder-free disposable gloves, and an amphibian-appropriate supplement.

## Housing

Our recommended starting adult enclosure is 24 × 18 × 18 in (61 × 46 × 46 cm; L × W × H) for one animal. Larger usable space is encouraged. These dimensions are a husbandry recommendation, not a species-specific experimentally proven threshold. A compatible pair can use this footprint with dense cover and multiple feeding sites; groups need additional usable space and close monitoring.

Provide multiple hides across the warm-to-cool and moist-to-drier gradient, covered travel routes and species-appropriate burrowing or low climbing structure. Fix heavy decor to the floor before adding loose substrate so digging cannot undermine it.

Juveniles may use a furnished adult enclosure when food intake, hydration and waste can be monitored. A temporary grow-out enclosure should still offer choice and cover. Quarantine newcomers separately

with dedicated tools and a substrate that permits health monitoring; arrange veterinary assessment for unknown-origin animals.

## Lighting & UVB

Provide roughly 10-12 hours of visible daylight followed by darkness. A measured UV Index (UVI) around 0.3-0.7 at the most exposed usable site, declining to near zero inside retreats, is our conservative starting recommendation. Species-specific optimal UV doses are not established for these frogs; low exposure is optional only when substantial shade and safe temperatures can be maintained.

Measure exposure at the animal's back height with an appropriate UVI meter, such as a Solarmeter 6.5. Lamp percentage, wattage and a fixed distance alone do not establish exposure: reflectors, mesh, perch height, plant growth and lamp age change output. Keep glass/plastic out of the UV path, follow fixture safety instructions and provide complete shade. Replace or reassess lamps according to measured output and manufacturer guidance.

## Heating & Temperature

- Warm retreat / local air: 70-76°F (21-24°C).
- Cool-zone air: 68-72°F (20-22°C).
- Nighttime air: 65-72°F (18-22°C) for healthy established animals.

Create the gradient on one side rather than heating every hide to the same temperature. Use a compatible thermostat on each heat source; a manual lamp dimmer does not replace thermostatic protection. Secure the probe and verify temperatures independently: probe thermometers measure air/retreat temperature, while an infrared thermometer measures exposed surfaces.

Use appropriately guarded overhead warmth when needed. Keep animals clear of hot fixtures, avoid heat rocks, and switch visible lights off at night. Night heat is needed only when the room falls below the appropriate range; use a thermostat-controlled lightless source if necessary.

Most suitable rooms need no additional heat. Avoid an intense basking spot and prolonged temperatures around or above 80°F (27°C). A sealed vivarium can overheat rapidly, so room cooling, ventilation and placement deserve attention.

## Humidity & Ventilation

80-100% in sheltered microhabitats with controlled ventilation; no waterlogged floor. Treat readings as a starting pattern rather than a number to chase regardless of substrate, airflow or animal behavior.

Measure humidity in a representative occupied zone, away from a freshly sprayed surface. Provide sheltered moisture choices while retaining airflow. Persistent condensation, sour odor, flooded soil or surfaces that never dry indicate a setup problem. Ventilation and hydration must be adjusted together rather than simply sealing all vents.

## Water & Hydration

Reliable hydration comes from consistently humid retreats and moist leaf litter. A water dish is optional; if used, make it very shallow with several easy exits. A deep decorative pond is not required and can create drowning and sanitation hazards.

Use clean water conditioned for both chlorine and chloramine, or an appropriate mineral-balanced amphibian-safe supply. Standing tap water does not reliably remove chloramine. Unremineralized distilled/RO water should not be the routine soaking or drinking supply; mineral-free misting systems require attention to the animal's full water exposure.

Use mineral-balanced amphibian-safe water for direct animal exposure. Ensure the drainage layer cannot become accessible to frogs and that wastewater does not rise into their living substrate.

## **Substrate**

A proper dart frog substrate should hold humidity while draining well. A good setup includes a drainage layer, screen separator, 2-3" of ABG mix or dart frog substrate, and a thick layer of clean leaf litter on top.

Sphagnum moss, cork pieces, seed pods, and plant roots help create damp microclimates.

A bioactive cleanup crew is strongly recommended. Springtails are especially useful because they help control mold and also provide tiny supplemental prey. Dwarf isopods can also be used, but very large isopods may bother small frogs or compete for food.

Spot clean visible waste as needed. In a mature bioactive enclosure, the substrate is not replaced on a strict monthly schedule like a simple reptile setup, but it still needs maintenance. Replace broken-down leaf litter, remove spoiled food, trim plants, and watch for sour smells, standing water in the soil layer, or excessive mold.

## **Food & Feeding**

Golfo Dulce poison dart frogs are strict insectivores. They should not be fed crested gecko diet, fruit puree, vegetables, or dead insects. Their diet should be made up of live, appropriately sized invertebrates.

Flightless fruit flies are the staple feeder. Small juveniles usually start best on *Drosophila melanogaster* and springtails, while larger juveniles and adults can also take *Drosophila hydei*. Other useful feeders can include springtails, rice flour beetles, bean beetles, pinhead crickets, small black soldier fly larvae, and tiny isopods. Do not feed wild insects because of pesticide and parasite risk. How often Golfo Dulce poison dart frogs need to eat depends on age:

Juveniles - small meals daily or at least 5-6x/week Adults - fruit flies or other tiny feeders 3-5x/week Feed only what the frogs can reasonably hunt down before the next feeding. A few extra fruit flies in the vivarium are normal, but large numbers of leftover flies mean the frogs are being overfed or the feeding amount needs adjustment.

## **Supplements**

Use an amphibian-appropriate calcium/multivitamin program containing suitable preformed vitamin A, following the product's labeled schedule and specialist guidance. Many feeder insects are calcium-poor; varied prey alone does not guarantee a balanced captive diet.

Coordinate calcium, D3, vitamin A and UVB rather than stacking several products. Potency varies between brands, so a universal dose in scoops or days is misleading. Keep supplements fresh, store as directed and do not use high-dose vitamin A to treat suspected deficiency without veterinary assessment.

## Decor & Enrichment

Decorations are not optional for dart frogs. They provide security, humidity pockets, breeding surfaces, and natural foraging areas. Good decor can include cork bark, seed pods, leaf litter, small hides, bromeliads, pothos, peperomia, creeping fig, mossy wood, and other sturdy tropical plants.

Because *Phyllobates vittatus* can be shy at first, dense cover is important. The more secure the frogs feel, the more likely they are to come out during the day and behave naturally. Provide open leaf-litter feeding areas, but avoid a bare enclosure.

## Handling & Behavior

Limit handling to necessary maintenance or health checks. Use clean powder-free disposable gloves moistened with amphibian-safe water and support the whole body. Avoid oils, soaps, lotions and squeezing. A suitable cup is often safer for transfers.

Do not pull a buried frog out merely to make it visible. Frequent hiding alone is not proof of illness, but hiding plus weight loss or other changes needs assessment.

## Cleaning & Routine Maintenance

Daily: check the animal's access to water/appropriate moisture, temperatures, visible condition and equipment. Remove feces, contaminated material, dead feeders and spoiled food promptly.

Regularly: clean dishes and feeding surfaces, check thermostats and probes, inspect decor stability and maintain ventilation. Bioactive systems still require waste checks, food removal, plant care and drainage maintenance; they are not self-cleaning.

Record appetite, activity, shed/molt history and weight or body condition when safe. Arrange veterinary assessment for unexplained changes. Quarantine new animals with dedicated tools, and disinfect only with a suitable product used at the label dilution/contact time, then rinse and dry as required before return.

## Cohabitation

A compatible same-species pair or carefully monitored small group may be maintained in a larger, densely furnished enclosure with multiple feeding sites. Do not mix species or distinct breeding localities. Track each frog's weight/condition and separate for chasing, food exclusion, injury or persistent hiding. Group tolerance does not eliminate territorial behavior.

## Shedding, Molting & Seasonal Changes

Skin shedding can be normal, and frogs may eat shed skin. Persistent abnormal skin, wounds, weakness or redness need assessment. Do not peel skin, force a soak or use home treatments on amphibian skin.

## Reproduction

These frogs lay eggs and have an aquatic tadpole stage. Successful breeding requires species-appropriate egg/tadpole management, safe water chemistry, tiny foods and plans for offspring. Routine pet care does not require breeding; do not add deep water to the adult enclosure simply to encourage it.

## Common Health Concerns

- Poor body condition or feeding decline: check the full gradient, hydration and food quality; arrange assessment for persistent refusal accompanied by weight loss.
- Calcium/vitamin imbalance: weakness, tremors, a soft or misshapen jaw or abnormal limbs require veterinary assessment; extra high-dose supplements are not a substitute for diagnosis.
- Skin, shed or injury problems: repeated retained skin, wounds, swelling or abnormal discoloration deserve prompt attention.
- Respiratory or systemic illness: labored/open-mouth breathing at rest, marked lethargy, loss of balance, persistent diarrhea or rapid deterioration require an experienced exotic veterinarian.
- Abnormal red patches, sores or bloating can indicate serious disease, including bacterial infection; "red leg" is not a reliable home diagnosis. Do not apply reptile creams, oils, honey or undosed medications to the skin.
- Difficulty capturing prey can occur with several conditions, including vitamin A deficiency. Obtain veterinary assessment rather than treating with concentrated vitamin A.

## Sources & Review Information

Reviewed October 2026 · RRE version 2.0. Care targets are practical starting recommendations informed by natural history, published work and captive experience. For less-studied species, enclosure dimensions, feeding frequencies, UVI ranges and lifespan estimates are not experimentally validated universal thresholds. Adjust for the individual, locality, life stage and veterinary advice.

American Museum of Natural History. Amphibian Species of the World: identity and native range.  
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Vitamin A supplementation study in *Phyllobates vittatus* tadpoles (2024). Larval findings do not establish adult doses.  
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